

News

'The most anti-biking bill in history' — Iowa's near-total bike ban proposal is bizarre and alarming

Advocates say the bill, framed as a safety measure, would "functionally and explicitly ban biking on most of Iowa's roadways"



By Kristin Jenny | Published 9 February 2026 In [News](#)



(Image credit: Getty Images)



There are few greater joys as a cyclist than riding a quiet road surrounded by nature. In Iowa, that experience is easy to find: the state's **50,000 square miles of farmland** are rich in rolling, low-traffic roads, giving its nearly **one million cyclists** access to scenic routes alongside 2,000 miles of multi-use trails and a vast network of rural local, county, and state highways.

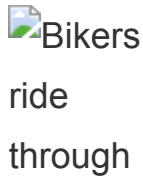
But a bill introduced to the Iowa State Legislature on January 28, 2026, by the House Public Safety Committee, threatens to put a stop to that.

House Study Bill 637 (HSB 637) could sharply limit where cyclists are allowed to ride by proposing that, among other limiters, "a person shall not use a device on a roadway with a speed limit above 25 miles per hour."

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Under the bill's definitions, a "device" includes bicycles, electric personal mobility devices, and pedestrian conveyances such as wheelchairs, scooters, and skateboards

Because most rural roads carry posted speed limits well above 25 mph, the proposal would effectively prohibit bicycle access across large stretches of Iowa's rural road network.



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What's more, the bill also aims to place limits on bike couriers, noting that, "While using a device, a person shall not carry a package, bundle, or article that prevents the person from keeping the person's hands on the handlebars...at all times."

HSB 637 also addresses anti-locking and anti-skid braking mechanisms, requiring that all devices be able to brake in a way that allows skidding. This conflicts with modern bicycle and e-bike hydraulic braking systems, which are designed to provide controlled stopping power that reduces the risk of wheel lock-ups and skidding for rider safety.

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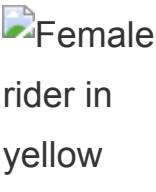
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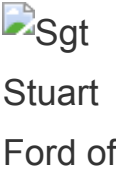
"In our very humble opinion, this is the most anti-biking bill in the history of the Iowa Legislature," said Luke Hoffman, executive director of the Iowa Bicycle Coalition. "HSB 637 is disguised as a bike safety bill. But what it really does is, functionally and explicitly, ban biking on most of Iowa's roadways."

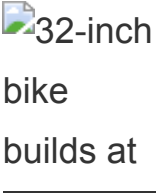
Beyond access concerns, cycling advocates point to the industry’s significant economic footprint across the state.

According to a 2025 study by the Iowa Bicycle Coalition, cycling generates an estimated \$1.4 billion in gross state product annually and supports roughly 21,000 jobs across Iowa. The group also estimates that cycling-related volunteerism and social capital development contribute approximately \$7.1 million statewide.

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If adopted, the proposal would also carry criminal consequences.

HSB 637 states that individuals who use a bicycle or other covered device on a road with a speed limit above 25 mph would be subject to a "simple misdemeanor," carrying a criminal record, penalties of up to 30 days in jail, and fines of nearly \$900.

Those mandates, and their consequences, would extend beyond individual riders to organised cycling events as well.

RAGBRAI, one of Iowa's best-known cycling events, is the world's oldest and largest multi-day bicycle touring ride. The route spans roughly 390 miles from border to border each year, drawing approximately 30,000 riders in 2023 alone. Should HSB 637 pass, the future of events like RAGBRAI remains uncertain. The bill does not clearly outline what exceptions, if any, would be permitted.

Fortunately, cyclists across Iowa can breathe a cautious sigh of relief, at least for now. The bill’s advance **was paused last week** with Public Safety Committee Chair Mike Vondran stating it "needs more work," offering little detail beyond that.

For the moment, that stall shields riders from the alarming roadway restrictions outlined in HSB 637. But the proposal could still be revised, reintroduced and brought back for a vote in a future session.



Kristin Jenny Freelance Contributor



Kristin Jenny is an elite triathlete based near Boulder, Colorado. Although most of her time is spent in aerobars somewhere in the mountains, she finds time to enjoy eating decadent desserts, hiking with her husband and dog, and a good true crime podcast.

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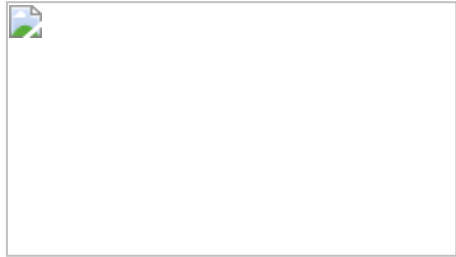
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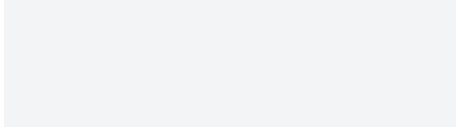
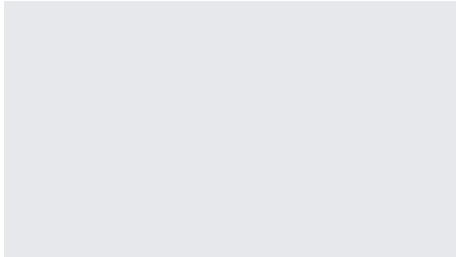
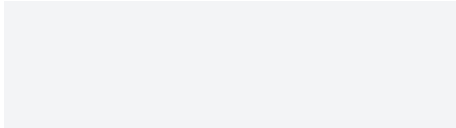
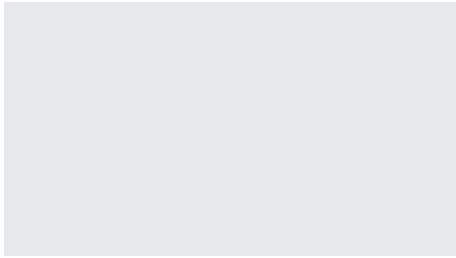
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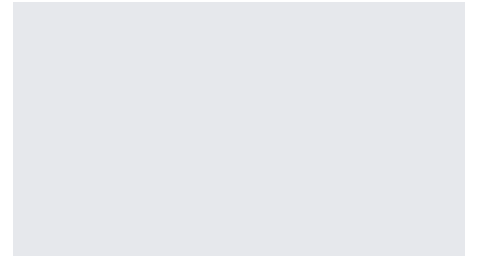
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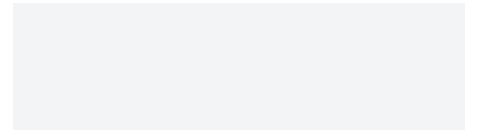


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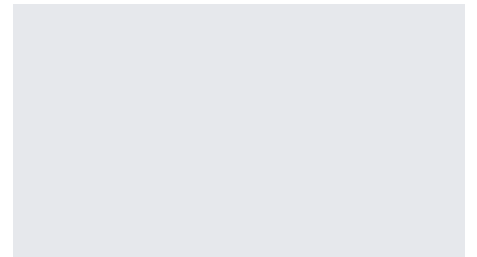
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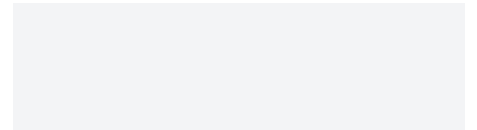


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